

Containment feeding is one practical way that livestock producers can manage feed shortages during periods of seasonal and climate variability. When used strategically, it can support livestock productivity while protecting pastures and maintaining ground cover during challenging times.

Dr Penny Schulz, producer and Livestock Technical Adoption Officer at the SA Drought Hub, utilises a containment feeding system as a flexible management option that supports productivity across a range of seasonal conditions. “Containment feeding is a great strategic tool that can be used on farm, not just in tough seasonal conditions like drought, but to fill feed gaps that happen just seasonally every year,” she says.

Dr Schulz leads the SA Drought Hub’s ‘Containment Feeding to Boost Business Performance and Resilience’ project, which was developed to address gaps in technical expertise, access to consistent information and producer uptake. While many producers recognise the benefits of containment feeding, implementation can be complex, requiring decisions around animal selection, nutrition, timing, infrastructure and cost that can be daunting to make without support, or during tough times.

The need for this support was accelerated during project development in 2023, when SA producers experienced a failed spring, and rapidly worsening seasonal conditions. Advisor training was prioritised to ensure producers could access timely, practical guidance during one of the state’s driest periods on record.

Advisors were upskilled via a ‘Train-the-Trainer’ model and linked with farming systems groups to support long-term regional capability beyond the life of the project. In addition, resources were developed in parallel to ensure consistent messaging.

Advisor and livestock consultant Ash Wachtel says the program addressed a longstanding gap in accessible, practical resources. “Before, I found resources on containment feeding really scattered. It took a lot of time to find the information you were looking for. This program brought everything into one spot and gave us a really up to date, well-researched resource,” says Ash. On-farm visits were a key component, allowing advisors to assess existing or planned infrastructure and provide tailored recommendations.

The training has strengthened advisor confidence as well as technical knowledge. Dr Schulz notes that improved decision-making capability has been one of the most important outcomes, with advisors better equipped to support producers to make informed investments and manage containment feeding systems effectively.

For producers, the benefits have translated directly to on-farm outcomes. Sheep producer Robbie Bateman has invested in containment feeding infrastructure to improve efficiency and protect paddocks ahead of lambing. “It lets the grass grow out in the paddock, leading up to lambing. More grass I grow, the more sheep I can run. The more sheep I can run, the more efficient the business is, and more.”

By building practical skills and confidence using containment feeding systems, the SA Drought Hub is helping strengthen drought resilience in livestock production systems and supporting farm businesses to stay profitable during tough times.

To find out more information about the Sheep Containment Feeding to Boost Business Performance and Resilience project, visit the [South Australian Drought Hub website](#).

Watch the video to see how containment feeding can contribute to strengthening livestock production and building drought resilience in South Australia.

Video duration: 7 mins 12 secs

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund (FDF). Funded through the Drought Resilience Adoption and Innovation Hubs program, the video features the Sheep Containment Feeding Project delivered by the South Australian Drought Hub, in partnership with Talking Livestock and Livestock SA, and highlights how practical tools and advisory support are helping producers build confidence and improve drought resilience through containment feeding.

Learn more about the [Future Drought Fund](#).

[Recording begins]

Music plays.

Dr Penny Schulz [00:39]

Containment feeding is a great strategic tool that can be used on farm, not just in tough seasonal conditions like drought, but to fill feed gaps that happen just seasonally every year, so that we can ensure our ewes or even our cattle are in good condition to be productive and profitable, and be able to do that really effectively, and also have benefits that are in the landscape as well for pasture and ground cover. Containment feeding, whether it's sheep or cattle, is when you take the ewes or the cattle off paddocks and you put them into pens that are suitable for feeding, generally for longer term feeding, and you meet all their nutritional requirements in those pens and containment feeding, or confinement feeding, as it's often called well, is generally a temporary measure to fill a feed gap.

The Sheep Containment Feeding Project was in development a few years ago, because we saw there was a lack of resources, a lack of confidence and technical expertise in the regions, and we wanted to be able to provide producers more support in the containment feeding space.

Many producers know that containment feeding can be beneficial when used at the right time, but actually implementing it on farm can be really challenging - with a lot of decisions to make about what ewes to feed, when to feed them, for how long, with what - and so in practice that can be quite challenging and can be expensive too. While we're developing that project in 2023, we experienced a really, really dry failed spring, so we had to increase the rate of our project development so that we could meet the need, both for advisors and producers, and that ended up being a really good move.

We put advisors through training late in 2023 and following on from there, we had the worst drought on record here in South Australia and across a lot of the southeastern part of the country. It was really important that we met the needs of advisors and producers when they really needed that support.

We created resources for both advisors and producers in parallel, so that were matched really well, and we used the technical expertise of Deb Scammell from Talking Livestock - a reputable nutritionist, to help us not only view those resources, but deliver the 'Train the Trainer' for advisors. We put out an expressions of interest, and we also ensured that advisors had a connection with a farming systems group, because we wanted to ensure there was a legacy for this project, that all the regions that were interested in this space had an advisor that was trained and had more confidence working and supporting producers.

Ash Wachtel [03:09]

I took part in the containment feeding program because I saw it as an opportunity to upskill myself on best practice recommendations for containment feeding. Before, I found resources on containment feeding really scattered. It took a lot of time to find the information you were looking for. This program brought everything into one spot and gave us a really up to date, well-researched resource.

As part of the program, we were able to get out on farm and see the producers paddocks, possible locations for containment pens and their infrastructure, and what they already had.

Dr Penny Schulz [03:43]

Not only do advisors have additional skills in animal health and nutrition, particularly focus on containment feeding but they've got more confidence in the decision making process, which I think's the most important bit around containment feeding.

Ash Wachtel [03:56]

Sometimes producers might think they might not have a suitable area for containment feeding. Also, from the infrastructure perspective, costs can be a big thing if they don't previously have any type of feeding system, that can be quite a large upfront cost. By being able to get out on farm, see what they've got already and make those recommendations, they can feel confident that they are putting their money into the right place.

Robbie Bateman [04:21]

Huge benefit for containment feeding for me is efficiency. I've invested in lick feeders. Each feeder will hold about 3 tonne grain. Sheep are just happy and content on them. They've got feed there 24/7, and they're calm and relaxed. It lets the grass grow out in the paddock, leading up to lambing. More grass I grow, the more sheep I can run. The more sheep I can run, the more efficient the business is, and more profitable.

Paul Serle [04:49]

We sort of dived in the containment feeding program because we had a little bit of an interest in seeing what some other people were doing on a couple farms, and always trying to learn a bit more about how we can improve things on the farm here. The program gave us a bit more of a background knowledge on the nutritional requirements of the ewes, and when they're in containment, and what we needed to be feeding.

There's also very practically based too, and the other had bonus was networking with, with the other other farmers that were there and their experiences and what they were going through and how they were thinking about approaching it.

Ash Wachtel [05:19]

The program has made me better at my job because I'm providing more up-to-date advice. I'm feeling confident in that information, and I feel like I'm implementing it a lot faster on property. And I feel like the uptake from producers has been a lot quicker.

Dr Penny Schulz [05:35]

Containment feeding's a strategic tool that producers can use on the farm to effectively fill a feed gap. Some years that feed gap is short and some years that feed gap is really large. Successful containment feeding in a sheep production system means your ewes in better condition. Your pastures are in better condition. You're being able to maintain ground cover more easily as well in those tougher seasons, and you'll be able to have more control.

You need to manage water and health aspects of containment feeding, but it certainly had a lot of on farm benefits going through those really tough drought years.

Robbie Bateman [06:11]

Being drought resilient is important for us. It costs a lot of money to maintain and grow those pastures during drought times. That's compromised, so if we can maintain that pastures in and improve them in dry conditions, it's a benefit for everybody.

Dr Penny Schulz [06:27]

We want to have tools in our toolbox as producers to be able to maintain productivity and profitability and that builds resilience into our farm businesses, and also meets the needs of our ewes, as far as wellbeing and nutrition goes.

Paul Serle [06:43]

Programs like this are important for Australian agriculture because it just allows farmers to learn something different and adopt new practices on their farms that make them more profitable and

ensures food supply for the nation and export for the country, and just has an overall benefit to everybody.

Recording ends [07:12]

A screen displays the logos for the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and the Future Drought Fund.

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the continuous connection of First Nations Traditional Owners and Custodians to the lands, seas and waters of Australia. We recognise their care for and cultivation of Country. We pay respect to Elders past and present, and recognise their knowledge and contribution to the productivity, innovation and sustainability of Australia's agriculture, fisheries and forestry industries.

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